

was a good salary in 1973. So, I joined the company as a computer engineer in the System Engineering and Computer Services Department.” As a part of that team, Prof. Sadagopan was actively involved in the computerisation of materials management for IPCL!

That job gave Prof. Sadagopan exposure to the advanced applications of computer engineering. He got an opportunity to take special computer training from a team of German experts and some interesting projects like planning the road network and the bus network for Hyderabad and Delhi, and planning for the slurry pipeline of Kudremukh Iron Ore.

Prof. Sadagopan narrates, “I was having fun at my job; however, I wanted more fun and more opportunities to learn. Thus, I started looking for higher studies. Those days, there was no email facility, but I remembered Professor Ravindran who came from Purdue University to teach in IIT Madras. He had also given lectures in my engineering college at Guindy. So, I contacted him and he guided me to my higher studies. I cleared TOEFL and GRE and landed myself at Purdue University.” Purdue University is one of the largest engineering institutions in the United States. “The Purdue University President used to use a very nice marketing statement - The first man on the moon happens to be a Purdue alumnus; as of now, the last man on the moon also happens to be a Purdue alumnus!” says Prof. Sadagopan remembering his alma mater.

The Purdue University days were quite memorable for Prof. Sadagopan. That was a time when computer science was getting mainstream and the computer centre at Purdue was managed very well. In Prof. Sadagopan’s words, “Purdue was quite ahead of the computer revolution to solve diverse problems of humanity.” He enjoyed dabbling in large computing, large computational problem-solving, and decision support. He also got involved



Prof. S. Sadagopan receiving NDTV Digital Pioneer Award

in an optimisation library that was used by several departments—agriculture, engineering, science, and business—to use resources optimally. “We used to work on computer programs that were open, much before the word open source was invented. It was a set of Fortran programs for linear and integer optimisation used by the whole university,” Prof. Sadagopan explains. Later he applied that experience to share scientific and engineering program libraries at IIT Kanpur.

While discussing the influence of faculty members at Purdue University, Prof. Sadagopan mentions, “Professor Ravindran at Purdue University influenced me a lot. His way of assessing students was different from the traditional methods. He used to say that students do not haggle for more marks if they know what they deserve and why they deserve it. His explanation helped me to develop the habit of giving copious notes for all the quizzes, homework, and examinations that I corrected as a teaching assistant. I always find that students take exams seriously not only

for obtaining marks but also for learning perspective; it is for the teachers to provide that learning environment”

Purdue University is located near Chicago, the place where Swami Vivekananda represented India at the Parliament of the World’s Religions in 1893. “Because of my connection with Ramakrishna Math, I was very curious to know about Swami Vivekananda’s coverage and journey in Chicago, as I was

inspired by the way Swami Vivekananda presented India there. I found something amazing about it in Purdue library—I could access the newspaper of 1893 in 1976 and I was able to find Swami Vivekananda’s coverage in the local newspapers of the United States. I was amazed to see Swami Vivekananda’s picture on the front page of the Chicago Tribune though his name was depicted in the typical American style—Swami as his first name and Ananda as his last name!.”

Facilitating India’s technological progress

While Prof. S. Sadagopan’s voyage has been a tapestry of intriguing experiences, his impact on India’s technological landscape remains unparalleled. From his decision to return to India immediately after pursuing his PhD abroad to his instrumental role in pivotal IT initiatives, his journey has been an embodiment of dedication and strategic vision. Though he does not consider it as a strategic decision, he prefers to let life go as it is.

Awards and Accolades

- Fulbright Fellowship (1995)
- Champion of Humanity, Award of Hindustan Chamber of Commerce (2009)
- Rotary Honor of Vocational Excellence by Rotary Northwest Bangalore District 3190 (2013)
- Engineering Watch “Campus Preparedness” Award (2015)
- Cisco NDTV “Digital Pioneer” Award (2016)
- Distinguished Alumnus Award, College of Engineering Guindy (2021)
- IT Visionary Award, StrategINK (2023)